

I used to think grief was sadness.

I thought grief was crying when someone died. Missing them. Looking at old photographs and feeling that familiar ache in your chest. I thought grief was something that happened to you, something you endured for a while, and eventually something you got over.

I don't think I understood grief at all.

Grief is much stranger than sadness.

Sometimes grief is crying so hard you can't breathe.

Sometimes it is staring at the wall for an hour because you cannot convince yourself to get up.

Sometimes it is making tea and forgetting why you walked into the kitchen.

Sometimes it is opening your phone to call someone before remembering that you can't.

Sometimes it is laughing at something and then feeling guilty because, for a few seconds, you forgot that someone is gone.

Sometimes grief is silence.

Complete silence.

There are people who become almost unable to speak after a devastating loss. Not because they have nothing to say. They have too much inside them.

The words are there somewhere, but they cannot get from the mind to the mouth.

Someone asks, "Are you okay?"

And you know the answer.

You know exactly what you want to say.

*No.*

But your mouth doesn't cooperate.

So you nod.

Or shake your head.

Or stare at them.

Or type the words into your phone because somehow writing is easier than speaking.

There is something particularly strange about losing your ability to speak when you have spent your entire life believing that words are how human beings communicate pain.

Sometimes there simply aren't any.

How do you explain that someone existed yesterday and doesn't exist today?

How do you explain what it feels like when the world outside you continues behaving normally while your internal world has been completely rearranged?

How do you say, "I watched someone I love disappear," without the sentence sounding as inadequate as it actually is?

So you say nothing.

And people might misunderstand the silence.

They might think you're calm.

They might think you're coping well.

They might think you don't want to talk.

They might even think you don't care.

Meanwhile, inside your head, there can be an entire conversation happening at once.

This is partly because grief isn't only emotional.

It affects the body and the brain.

When we experience something overwhelming, the brain's threat systems can become highly activated. Stress hormones rise. Attention narrows. Sleep can become disrupted. Appetite can change. Memory and concentration can become unreliable.

This is why a grieving person can forget simple things.

You can walk into a room and have no idea why you're there.

You can read the same sentence five times and realize you haven't absorbed a word.

You can forget appointments.

Lose your keys.

Send a message and immediately forget what you wrote.

You can sit in front of a television and realize you've been staring at the same scene without knowing what happened.

It isn't laziness.

It isn't stupidity.

The brain is allocating its resources somewhere else.

There is an enormous amount of information to process when someone dies.

The brain has to reconcile something intellectually that the emotional parts of us may not yet accept.

*They were here.*

*They are not here.*

Both facts have to somehow exist in the same mind.

And that takes time.

This is why grief can feel like a kind of cognitive disorientation.

Your life has changed, but your habits haven't caught up.

You may still expect their name to appear on your phone.

You may still think about buying something they liked.

You may hear a familiar voice in a crowd and turn around.

You may see a person who looks like them from behind and experience a tiny jolt of recognition before reality catches up.

For a moment, your brain says, *There they are.*

Then it remembers.

And that tiny moment can break your heart all over again.

Grief also has a peculiar relationship with time.

A day can feel endless.

An hour can feel like five minutes.

You can spend an entire afternoon doing almost nothing and still feel exhausted by the end of it.

Because grief is work.

Invisible work.

Your brain is constantly trying to understand a new reality.

And your body can feel the cost.

You might be exhausted even after sleeping.

You might sleep for twelve hours and wake up feeling as though you haven't rested at all.

You might lose your appetite.

Or eat because eating is one of the few things you can control.

Your chest might feel heavy.

Your stomach might hurt.

Your muscles might ache.

You might feel restless and unable to sit still.

You might feel numb.

And numbness can frighten people because they think grief is supposed to look like tears.

It isn't.

Sometimes the brain protects you by turning down the volume.

You can know that something devastating has happened without being able to feel the full force of it yet.

You might look at everyone crying and wonder why you aren't.

Then three days later, you are in the supermarket reaching for milk and suddenly you're crying beside the refrigerators.

There is no schedule.

Grief doesn't care whether you are at work.

It doesn't care whether you're having dinner with friends.

It doesn't care whether you have an exam tomorrow.

It doesn't care that you promised someone you'd be somewhere at eight.

It arrives when it wants.

A song can do it.

A smell can do it.

A photograph can do it.

A particular phrase can do it.

Sometimes nothing obvious happens at all.

You're brushing your teeth.

And suddenly you remember.

There is no warning.

This is one of the reasons grief can make people feel as though they have lost control of themselves.

You don't know when the next wave is coming.

And the waves aren't always sadness.

There can be anger.

An almost irrational anger at people who are still alive.

Anger at doctors.

Anger at God.

Anger at the person who died.

Anger at yourself.

Anger at the person who said something insensitive.

Anger at the woman laughing loudly in the next room because how dare she laugh when your world has ended?

Then guilt arrives.

*Why am I angry?*

*Why did I laugh yesterday?*

*Why did I feel relieved when I left the hospital?*

*Why am I annoyed that people keep calling me?*

*Why did I enjoy my food?*

Grief can make ordinary human reactions feel like moral failures.

They aren't.

You can be devastated and still laugh.

You can miss someone terribly and still become irritated by something stupid.

You can love someone and also feel exhausted by the expectations surrounding their death.

You can want company and desperately want to be left alone.

You can cry in the morning and laugh at night.

None of these things cancel the others.

Grief is not proof that you loved someone enough.

There is no correct amount of suffering.

Some people cry openly.

Some people become practical.

They organize things.

They make phone calls.

They arrange transport.

They cook.

They answer messages.

They become the person everyone relies on.

And sometimes that person collapses weeks later.

Because when there is something to do, the brain can temporarily focus on the task.

Then the tasks end.

Everyone goes home.

The funeral is over.

The visitors stop coming.

The phone stops ringing.

And suddenly there is silence.

That can be when grief becomes louder.

This is why telling someone, "Be strong," can be such a strange thing to ask.

Strong for whom?

Strong in what way?

Sometimes strength is crying.

Sometimes strength is admitting, "I cannot do this today."

Sometimes strength is asking someone to sit beside you without speaking.

Sometimes strength is leaving a room because you have reached your limit.

Sometimes strength is simply eating breakfast.

Grief can also change the way we understand safety.

When you lose someone suddenly, especially when you witnessed it, the world can begin to feel unpredictable.

You become aware that ordinary moments are not guaranteed.

You might check whether people are breathing when they sleep.

You might panic when someone doesn't answer their phone.

You might become frightened by hospitals.

You might replay the last conversation you had with someone.

You might become hyperaware of every little symptom or change in the people you love.

The brain is constantly scanning for danger because it has learned something frightening:

*People can disappear.*

And once you have learned that lesson through experience, it can be difficult to convince yourself that everything is fine.

This is also why grief can bring back older grief.

One loss can unlock another.

A new goodbye can reopen an old wound.

You can think you have healed from something because you learned how to function around it.

Then another loss happens.

Suddenly you're standing in the middle of memories you haven't visited in years.

You realize that grief has a memory.

The body remembers things the conscious mind has learned to live around.

A particular hospital smell.

The sound of medical equipment.

A certain kind of silence.

Someone holding your hand.

A room suddenly becoming still.

And suddenly you aren't only grieving the person you lost today.

You're remembering everyone you've ever had to lose.

This is where grief becomes complicated.

Because we often imagine grief as moving forward.

But sometimes grief moves sideways.

It reaches into the past.

It finds old pain.

It reminds you of the person you were when another loss happened.

And suddenly you are grieving for them too.

Maybe this is why people sometimes say, "I don't know what's wrong with me."

There may be nothing wrong with you.

You may simply be carrying more than one loss at once.

And then there is the strange problem of memory.

At first, the final moments can become the loudest ones.

The hospital.

The phone call.

The last conversation.

The last look.

The last time you touched them.

The brain grabs onto the ending because it is trying to understand what happened.

But eventually, with time, other memories can become louder.

The way they laughed.

The way they used to annoy you.

The way they pronounced a particular word.

The clothes they always wore.

The ridiculous thing they once did that nobody else would find funny.

The ordinary moments you didn't know were precious because you were too busy living them.

This is one of the cruelest things about grief.

We often don't know we're making memories while we're making them.

We think we're having a Tuesday.

We're actually creating the memories we will someday ache for.

And perhaps that is why grief is so closely tied to love.

You cannot grieve someone you never loved.

The size of the absence tells you something about the size of the presence.

Someone occupied a space in your life.

Now there is an empty space where they used to be.

And the brain keeps reaching for them because it hasn't yet learned the new shape of your life.

I don't think we ever really "get over" the people we love.

That phrase has always seemed strange to me.

You don't get over a person as though they were an illness.

You learn to live in a world where they are no longer physically present.

At first, that world feels impossible.

Then, slowly, it becomes familiar.

You learn where the sharp edges are.

You learn which memories you can touch.

You learn that some days will hurt more than others.

You learn that laughing doesn't mean you've forgotten.

You learn that continuing to live isn't betrayal.

You learn that love can survive without somewhere physical to go.

And maybe that is what processing grief really means.

Not forgetting.

Not accepting everything neatly.

Not reaching some magical day when you stop missing them.

Maybe it means allowing the reality of the loss to become part of your life without allowing the loss to become the entirety of your life.

Maybe it means making room for both things.

The person you lost.

And the person you still are.

Because grief can convince you that you died with them.

You didn't.

Something changed.

Something was taken from you.

Something inside you may never be exactly the same.

But you are still here.

And perhaps, for a while, that is enough.

You don't need to be strong.

You don't need to have the right words.

You don't need to understand why you're crying, or why you aren't.

You don't need to know how you're going to live with it.

You can sit in the uncertainty.

You can be quiet.

You can ask someone to hold your hand.

You can write six words because six words are all you have.

You can say, *I don't understand.*

You can say, *I'm scared.*

You can say nothing at all.

Grief doesn't demand eloquence.

It only asks that you survive the reality of having loved someone who is no longer here.

And sometimes surviving looks remarkably ordinary.

Getting out of bed.

Drinking water.

Answering one message.

Taking a shower.

Eating half a sandwich.

Going outside.

Coming back home.

Going to sleep.

Waking up.

Doing it again.

Not because you're over it.

Because you're still here.

And maybe that is the first thing grief teaches us.

We are capable of carrying an unbearable amount of love.

Unfortunately, sometimes that love has nowhere to go except through us.